

Bastides

By the 13th and 14th centuries, experience had proved that walls punctuated by cylindrical towers were efficient for the defence of towns, cities and castles. In southwest France, several new fortified towns – *bastides* – were built, not only to protect residents but also to promote trade. Roughly following Roman town plans, bastides were built to strict grid layouts usually around a central square, with equal space allocated to each house. Not all were constructed to the same plan, but many shared certain characteristics, including a right-angled road layout of intersecting streets, wide thoroughfares, a church adjacent to the main square, and a market hall and *couverts* (covered arcades) close to the perimeter. People were offered incentives to settle in them and work on the surrounding land. Almost 700 bastides were built between 1222 and 1372, and while their architecture is not extraordinary, the plans are harmonious and became copied elsewhere. Bastide halls and churches were often originally constructed in wood, but later rebuilt in stone.



Cordes-sur-Ciel, Tarn, southern France